

Community Perceptions of Criminology Students as Future Police Officers

Introduction

Criminology students are widely associated with becoming police officers due to a strong, deeply embedded public linkage between Criminology education and law enforcement. Under Republic Act No. 11131, officially known as the Philippine Criminology Profession Act of 2018, the official scope of practice for registered criminologists extends significantly beyond traditional police service. The law explicitly encompasses diverse professional domains, including forensic science, document examination, ballistics, correctional administration, security management, probation and parole supervision, crime research, and academic instruction in higher education institutions (HEIs) offering the Bachelor of Science in Criminology program. This broader scope suggests that Criminology education is not limited to preparation for police work, but may also lead to various professional and academic career pathways.

Despite the comprehensive mandate of RA 11131, its application and integration across local colleges and universities in Dagupan City and surrounding communities may face a disconnect between academic curriculum standards and public perception. Higher education institutions offering Criminology programs are expected to align their curriculum with Commission on Higher Education (CHED) standards and RA 11131, which provides graduates with preparation for multi-faceted career pathways. However, community members may still associate Criminology primarily with police work because of various social, environmental, media/informational, psychological, and institutional factors. Social factors may include family expectations, community beliefs, and common assumptions about the profession. Environmental factors may involve the community's exposure to police-related activities and Criminology students in law-enforcement settings. Media and informational factors may arise from how television, social media, and other sources commonly portray criminologists and law enforcement personnel. Psychological factors may involve perceptions of authority, discipline, uniforms, and public safety. Institutional factors may include the way Criminology programs are presented, implemented, and experienced within educational institutions.

This persistent public narrowness may be influenced by complex societal, environmental, media, institutional, and psychological factors. Criminology students in local communities are prominently recognized through visible uniform practices, community immersion projects, tactical drills, and neighborhood law-enforcement activities. Media representation may further reinforce this stereotype by portraying Criminology strictly as a stepping stone to the Philippine National Police (PNP). Psychological, community, and institutional factors may also shape how the public understands the program. Although previous studies have discussed career preferences, media influence, and public perceptions of Criminology, there remains a need to examine how adult community members themselves explain their perception that Criminology students are future police officers, particularly within the local community of Quesban, Calasiao, Pangasinan. This study therefore seeks to explore the factors and reasons underlying this perception and the community's understanding of the broader career opportunities under RA 11131.

Statement of the Problem

This study seeks to understand how adult community members in Quesban, Calasiao, Pangasinan perceive Criminology students as future police officers.

1. How do adult community members in Quesban, Calasiao, Pangasinan describe their perception of Criminology students as future police officers?
2. What factors and reasons do community members identify as influencing their perception of Criminology students as future police officers?
3. How do community members describe their understanding of the broader scope of the Criminology profession and its alternative career paths under RA 11131?

Objectives

This study aims to explore how adult community members in Quesban, Calasiao, Pangasinan perceive Criminology students as future police officers. It also aims to identify and understand the factors and reasons that influence such perceptions based on the experiences and views of community members. Furthermore, this study aims to explore community members' understanding of the broader scope of the Criminology profession and its alternative career paths under Republic Act No. 11131.

Significance of the Study

This study will directly benefit Criminology students of Universidad de Dagupan by providing insights into how community members perceive their chosen field of study and their possible career paths. The findings may help students better understand the public expectations and stereotypes associated with Criminology, enabling them to better communicate that the profession extends beyond traditional police work.

The study may also contribute to future researchers who wish to examine public perceptions, professional stereotypes, and awareness of the diverse career opportunities available to Criminology graduates under RA 11131.

Review of Related Literature (RRL)

Previous studies demonstrate a heavy preference among Criminology students toward law enforcement careers. For instance, empirical findings by Santos et al. (2020) revealed that over 75% of surveyed Criminology students chose the course with the primary intent of joining the Philippine National Police (PNP). Similarly, research by Garcia (2021) highlighted that media exposure, family expectations, and civil service security were the primary motivators driving students toward police roles.

However, studies focusing on public and community perceptions (e.g., Perez & Ramos, 2019) indicate that general community members frequently equate Criminology solely with police work due to visible uniform practice, community immersion activities, and historical institutional framing. Existing literature highlights a distinct gap in public knowledge regarding non-policing roles established under **RA 11131**, such as document examination, crime scene investigation, and correctional counseling. This study addresses this gap by directly examining community perspectives and the root factors shaping these perceptions.

Methodology

This study will employ a qualitative-descriptive research design to explore and describe the perceptions of adult community members regarding Criminology students as future police officers. This design is appropriate because the study seeks to obtain detailed descriptions of participants' views, experiences, and understanding of the Criminology profession within their natural community setting.

Participants

The participants of this study will consist of adult community members aged 18 years and above who are residents of Quesban, Calasiao, Pangasinan. Participants will be selected through purposive sampling based on predetermined inclusion criteria. Eligible participants must be residents of the selected barangay, aged 18 years and above, willing to participate in the study, and able to provide informed responses regarding their perceptions and understanding of Criminology students and the Criminology profession.

Data Gathering

Data will be gathered through face-to-face, semi-structured interviews using a researcher-developed interview guide that will be reviewed and validated by qualified individuals or the research adviser, as required by the institution. Prior to the interviews, the researchers will explain the purpose of the study and secure informed consent from each participant. With the participants' permission, interviews may be audio-recorded to ensure accurate transcription. The researchers will transcribe the interviews and review the responses carefully to identify recurring ideas, patterns, and meanings. The collected data will then be analyzed using thematic analysis to generate themes related to community perceptions, influencing factors, and understanding of the broader Criminology profession and its career pathways under RA 11131.